THE FANTASTICAL LOGIC GRID

Author Packet

Everything you need to write a story topic for the game and get it into the game: the writing rules, worked examples, and a step-by-step guide to uploading your story to the repository.

What	File	Use it for
Writing Guide and Upload Guide	This PDF	The rules, examples, and how to submit
Submission Form	Story-Submission-Form.docx	Drafting in Word, offline
Standard submission file	authors/submissions/TEMPLATE.md	What you actually upload
Checker	scripts/check-story-submission.mjs	Runs by itself on every upload

The one rule above all others: write every story part yourself, in your own words. That is what makes the stories yours under copyright. Facts belong to no one; your wording, your choice of events and how you arrange them are what you own.

1. How a story is built

The game assembles each story from one of each part below, chosen fresh every time. Six openings, six incidents, four mix-ups, four endings, six title words and two leads per category already make thousands of different stories, and the game never gives a player one they have already seen.

Part	What it does	Fill-ins you can use	Example
Title word	The title reads "The <word> <incident name>"	none	Frosty, Golden, Midnight
Opening	Sets the scene and says how many people	{n} or {N}, {many}	{N} {many} met at the corner, bundled up to their noses.
Incident	What is at stake: a name, a sentence and a prize	none	Fort | A snow fort went up behind the library. | the fort award
Mix-up	Why the facts got scrambled	none	The wind blew everyone's notes into the drifts.
Lead	Ties the answer to one category	{x}, {one}, {prize}	A mug of {x} cocoa sat steaming.
Ending	The reward shown when the puzzle is solved	{Fact}, {winner}, {prize}	{Fact}, so {winner} is the one behind {prize}!

What the fill-ins become

Fill-in	Becomes	Example
{n} / {N}	How many people (lowercase / capitalized)	four / Four
{many} / {one}	Your cast word, plural / single	neighbors / neighbor
{x}	The answer item for this puzzle	Mint
{Fact}	The full answer sentence	Nora drank Mint cocoa
{winner}	The answer person	Nora
{prize}	The incident's prize	the fort award

2. The rules (the checker tests each one)

- **Never name a category item or a cast name in any story part.** If "Oak" is a street on the grid, an opening that says "Oak Street" reads like a clue.
- Never use another topic's cast word in the same theme (no "sailors" in a railroad story).
- Openings must use {n} or {N} and {many}. Leads must use {x}. Endings must use {Fact}.
- Keep parts to about 10 to 25 words. A whole story must stay under 150 words.
- At least 5 categories, at least one numbered (a time or a number). Plain categories need exactly 8 items. Every item and cast name is used once only.
- Compare numbers with words like earlier/later or more/fewer, not higher/lower or above/below.
- Never write how many people there are as a number. Use {n}, so the story always matches the grid.
- Friendly for all ages: no violence words, no links, no code.

Good and not so good

Not so good	Better	Why
Four neighbors woke up to snow.	{N} {many} woke up to snow.	The head count changes with grid size; {N} always matches.
{N} {many} met on Oak Street.	{N} {many} met at the corner.	"Oak" is a Street item, so it gives away a clue.
A shovel leaned by the door.	A {x} shovel leaned by the door.	A lead must contain {x}, the answer item.
Nora won the award!	{Fact}, so {winner} won {prize}!	Real names change every puzzle; fill-ins keep it right.
had a higher score than	scored more points than	Higher/lower needs a note on which way the numbers run.

Writing tips

- Write the way you talk. Short sentences read best aloud, and the game reads stories aloud.
- Each opening should feel like a different moment: dawn, a storm, the night before, the last minute.
- Give incidents real stakes, and give each prize a "the": the lantern rescue, the fort award.
- Mix-ups are a chance for humor: a sneeze, a spilled drink, notes in a snowdrift.
- Read one finished story aloud. If you stumble, shorten it.

3. True stories (history topics)

A history topic puts the player in a situation like a real event, with an invented cast. On solve, a Fact card shows what really happened.

- **Real names, dates and places go only on the Fact card**, never in story parts. The cast is always invented.
- Build the Fact card from at least one trustworthy source you actually read (a museum, a national park, NASA, an encyclopedia), plus a second source that agrees.
- Write the Fact card in your own words: 2 to 4 plain sentences. Don't copy sentences from the source.
- Leave out famous quotes and song lyrics. Quotes can belong to someone; facts never do.
- When sources disagree on a detail (an exact day or count), keep it general: "December 1913".
- Turn facts into parts: a real moment becomes an incident, a real setting becomes an opening, a real confusion becomes a mix-up, and the jobs, tools and places of the time become category items.

4. Authorship and your records

- Write every part yourself. If you started from an AI draft, rewrite it fully, and say which parts on the form. Light edits to AI text don't make it yours.
- Upload from your own GitHub account. Each upload is a dated record of what you wrote.
- Keep your drafts. Your Word form and earlier versions show the work was yours.
- If you register a copyright, say which parts (if any) came from AI and leave them out of the claim.

This packet is general guidance, not legal advice.

5. Upload guide: step by step

All you need is a web browser and a free GitHub account. It takes about ten minutes the first time.

Step	What to do
1. Get the form	On GitHub, open **authors/submissions/TEMPLATE.md**. Click **Download raw file** (the download arrow at the top right of the file) and save it.
2. Name it	Rename your copy to your topic id, for example **snow-day.md**: lowercase letters, numbers and dashes only.
3. Fill it in	Open it in a plain text editor (Notepad, TextEdit in plain text mode, or VS Code). Type after each colon or dash. Leave lines that start with > alone. Drafted in Word? Copy each answer into the matching line.
4. Upload	In the repository, open **authors**, then **submissions**. Click **Add file**, then **Upload files**, and drag your file in.
5. Describe it	Under **Commit changes**, write a short message: **Add story submission: snow-day**.
6. New branch	Choose **Create a new branch for this commit and start a pull request**. Click **Propose changes**, then **Create pull request**.
7. Read the check	Within a minute the pull request shows **Story submission check**. Green check: ready. Red X: click **Details** to see each item marked FIX, in plain English.
8. Fix it	In the pull request, open **Files changed**, click the **...** menu on your file, choose **Edit file**, fix it, and commit to the same branch. The check runs again.
9. Add to the game	When the check is green, comment on the pull request (or ask Claude) to add the topic. Your story text goes in exactly as you wrote it.

Check it yourself first (optional)

With Node.js installed, from the repository folder:

```
node scripts/check-story-submission.mjs authors/submissions/snow-day.md
```

FIX lines must be fixed. CHECK lines are worth a second look but don't block. A passing file prints a sample story built from your parts and how many different storylines it can tell.

Common check messages

The check says	What to do
names the Street item "Oak"	Reword that part so it doesn't mention any grid item.
the lead ... must contain {x}	Add {x} where the answer item belongs.
Openings ... use {n} or {N} ... and {many}	Add the head count and cast word fill-ins.
needs exactly 8 items	Plain categories need 8 items, separated by commas.
is both a ... item and a cast name	Rename one; every item and name must be different.
answer "yes" to "I wrote every story part"	Confirm you wrote it, or rewrite the parts first.
Some stories run to 150 words	Shorten the longest openings, incidents and mix-ups.
looks like a real name (CHECK)	History topics: move real people to the Fact card.

Before you upload

- No story part names an item or a cast name.
- Every lead has {x}; every opening has {n} or {N} and {many}; every ending has {Fact}.
- Each item and cast name is used once only.
- History: every Fact card detail matches a source you read.
- The file is named your-topic-id.md and saved as plain text.